

OLD FRIEND BJP president J.P. Nadda meets TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu, Mar. 8

of full-timers, to reach out to the 480 million beneficiaries of the Modi government's social sector schemes at least three times in the past six months. "The bulk of the beneficiaries are from the backward communities—OBCs or Dalits—and they acknowledge this," says a senior BJP leader. During his interactions with party MLAs, MPs and office-bearers, PM Modi pushes them to talk about these schemes in their respective constituencies.

5 THE MODI GUARANTEE

Narendra Modi himself, though, remains the BJP's biggest trump card, say experts. His image as a doer, his vision of a Viksit Bharat (Developed India) and his immense popularity are the key factors that will decide whether the party makes electoral history this summer. As ace political strategist Prashant Kishor says, "People are voting for Brand Modi. He is seen not just as a Hindu *hriday samrat* who evokes nationalist pride but as someone who has brought laurels on foreign policy and who takes care of the poor through his welfare schemes." According to him, Brand Modi is built on the pillars of Hindutva, nationalism, beneficiaries and an enthused and aggressive cadre.

HOW THE CONGRESS GUARANTEES INCLUDING RS 1 LAKH ANNUALLY TO POOR WOMEN WILL FARE AGAINST THE MODI GUARANTEE IS WHERE THE REAL CONTEST WILL LIE

Pradeep Gupta, too, believes that Modi is the one who will now determine the future fortunes of the BJP. "At the peak of its popularity under A.B. Vajpayee and L.K. Advani," he says, "the BJP could win only 182 seats. It is Modi who has enabled two successive majorities for the BJP and who remains a key factor if the BJP is to achieve the big win for a third term. Without him, the BJP will fall back to 182 seats."

As in the past, Modi will be the chief campaigner for Election 2024 too. Till now, he has maintained a strategic balance between Hindutva and development, talking mostly of Vikas, Virasat and Vishwas and projecting himself as a unifier of the country against disparate and divisive forces. By cleverly enunciating a vision for Viksit Bharat in the distant future of 2047, he has avoided being pinned down to immediate targets, projecting instead an expansive future that only his continuity can "guarantee". Yet again, he has converted the general election into a US-style presidential contest, getting voters to compare his track record with that of his prime challenger, Rahul Gandhi, who has so far no experience of running a government. With the arrests of Soren and Kejriwal, as also the slew of corruption cases being filed against many other Opposition party leaders, the BJP is able to create an impression of Modi's clean rule vis-a-vis the corruption of others. Of course, the current furore over electoral bonds could put a spanner in the works. So far, though, the Opposition has been unable to convert it into an advantage or produce a convincing counter-narrative to challenge the BJP's seeming dominance.

There are, in fact, many issues the Opposition can use as ammunition to damage Modi and the BJP. Unemployment and, to some extent, inflation remain serious issues, as our MOTN poll reflected in February. The Opposition has promised welfare guarantees to offer relief to the poor and needy, the Congress even highlighting 25 such guarantees, including Rs 1 lakh a year to one woman in each of the poor families and making Minimum Support Prices (MSP) legal for all key crops. How these fare against the 'Modi Guarantee' to ensure rapid development and jobs is where the real contest will lie. As Swadesh Singh, a political science professor at Delhi University, says, "There is no denying the fact that the Indian economy is not in great shape, but the BJP and PM Modi are able to sell the idea that only they are the solution to fix it." That said, no election is a done deal, and the BJP and its allies will have to sweat it out to realise their ambition for 400-plus seats. Nothing is guaranteed till the final vote is cast—and counted. ■